PHOTOGRAPHY

A PEOPLE'S PHOTOGRAPHER

The lens with which Pablo Bartholomew has shot Naga tribes is both intimate and humanistic



Image Courtesy: PABLO BARTHOLOMEW





A CELEBRATION (clockwise from left) Pablo Bartholomew; The Ang of Shingachinyu Village (Apr. 1988); and Naga girls in western-style dresses made from traditional Naga weave, Kohima (May 1997)

A Naga chieftain of the Konyak tribe stands in front of his skull hut, the mounds of *memento mori* hinting at his peoples' historical association with head-hunting. Clad in Lohe (an Angami Naga shawl with stripes), a village woman carries wood for cooking. Traditional houses in the Willong village remain untouched by 20th century modernity. Pablo Bartholomew's *The Nagas* offers us an ethnographic glimpse of a community we barely know, but beyond ritual and daily life, his pictures also capture something more—aspiration.

Bartholomew's curiosity about the Naga tribes was piqued in childhood. He remembers his father, Richard Bartholomew, telling him stories of how he had escaped to Naga territory during the Japanese occupation of Burma in WW-II. Bartholomew's father, a photographer and art critic, finally settled down in Delhi. "Memory is strange," Bartholomew says. "Some bits get lost and then they come back in an intense manner years later. After my father died in 1985 at a fairly young age of 58, there were so many unanswered questions, and one of them was his escape from Burma in greater detail."

It was in 1989 that Bartholomew made his first long trip to the Naga region, but then, in an effort to rediscover his Burmese roots, he kept returning to villages in the area for another decade. Here he made friends, finding hope and succour in their stories of resilience. Many of the 72 photographs in this show are marked by an unsettling sense of calm and stillness. Seen together, they tell a story of strife and violence which years of ethnic conflict, warfare and insurgency have wrought. For Bartholomew, his journeys were dangerous but satisfying: "I think any time in the Northeastern hills and valleys is bad. But I took the risk for my ideas and quest."

PABLO BARTHOLOMEW'S The Nagas is on display at Mumbai's Nine Fish Art Gallery until March 24

Like his idol, the underrated photojournalist Kishor Parekh, Bartholomew's lens is intimate and humanistic, swinging deftly between documentary and anthropological realism. The most unique portraits in the show, however, are those that capture the indigenous fashion of the Naga people. One man has antelope horns dangling from his earlobe, while another has opted for a discarded battery. Elsewhere, Bartholomew chronicles a society on the cusp of change. Caught between tradition and modernity, the Naga youth, Bartholomew finds, are searching for their own voice. His project seems to argue that far from being monolithic, the Naga identity is, in fact, a glorious celebration of diversity. The 30-odd tribes in the Naga terrain, for instance,